Silica Awareness

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You may not have realized it but silica is everywhere. In fact it's present in about 95% of rocks, clays, sands and soils! Hazardous exposure in the workplace can occur when crystalline silica found in sand, quartz, and granite becomes airborne as dust from activities such as:

Demolition of brick, concrete, or masonry. Chipping, hammering, grinding, sawing, and drilling in concrete, brick or rock. Abrasive blasting using sand or from the material being blasted such as concrete. Crushing loading, hauling, and dumping of concrete or rock. Dry sweeping concrete, sand or rock dust. Trenching and excavating.

Once crystalline silica dust is inhaled it can potentially result in silicosis. Silicosis is a debilitating respiratory illness which may take years of silica exposure to develop. It can go undetected for years and only a complete work history, chest X-ray, and a lung-function test will determine whether or not a worker has the disease. Symptoms include: shortness of breath, severe cough, fatigue, loss of appetite, chest pains, and fever. Silicosis can also make a worker susceptible to emphysema and tuberculosis.

ENGINEERING CONTROLS

Silicosis is not curable but it is preventable by: controlling dust by using dust-containment systems, ventilation, or wetting down materials; using PPE such as respirators and dust masks; practicing good personal hygiene by washing, showering, regularly changing into clean clothes; never eating, drinking or smoking in dusty areas.